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Editorial

Adolescent psychopathology in times of change: Introduction to the special issue



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ABSTRACT

The aim of this special issue is to understand better the many changes in adolescent psychopathology have taken place over the last decades. The factors associated with adjustment problems and psychopathology in adolescence today are not necessarily the same as the factors that predicted problems and psychopathology in the past. But the basic strategies for connecting negative experiences with adolescent psychopathology remain as important today as they were for understanding adolescent psychopathology decades ago. This is well exemplified in the studies included in this Special Issue. What all these studies have in common is that parenting and the family environment are assumed to play a key role in adolescents' adjustment and psychopathology. Finally, given that all papers in this special issue are based on conference presentations at the 15th Biennial Conference of the European Association for Research on Adolescence (EARA), some more information on that conference is included in this introduction.

1. Adolescent psychopathology in times of change

The key message of this Special Issue is that changes in adolescent psychopathology have taken place over the last decades. What supports this claim? Seiffge-Krenke (this issue) points to immigration, economic crisis, and a prolonged dependence on parents for support, as new factors that impact adolescent lives today, and their psychopathology. Further, Shulman and Scharf (this issue) add the many technological innovations, like social media, that have entered into adolescents' lives, increasing societal unrest, economic uncertainties in families, and increased stress. Today, many children and adolescents in European countries, often recent immigrants, grow up in disadvantaged and unsafe neighborhoods around big cities, where they experience high levels of ethnic segregation, poverty, overcrowding, social problems, and parallel societal structures. Today, many adolescents are exposed to cyberbullying, which was unheard of just a few decades ago. Today, fear of the future is a major source of stress among adolescents in many countries (Seiffge-Krenke, this issue).

As the world changes, so must the lenses for understanding the mechanisms that explain how the negative everyday experiences of adolescents cross over to psychopathology. The factors associated with adjustment problems and psychopathology today are not necessarily the same as the factors that predicted problems and psychopathology yesterday. But the basic strategies for connecting negative experiences with adolescent psychopathology remain as important today as they were for understanding adolescent psychopathology decades ago. This is well exemplified in the studies included in this Special Issue.

A *time perspective*, a developmental or a development-psychopathology perspective, is essential for understanding stability and change, the precursors of adolescent problems, the pathways to and the consequences of adolescent problems for adult life, and the mechanisms behind change. In this Special Issue, Giannotta and Rydell, using data over eight years on a community sample, ask whether mother-child relationships mediate or moderate the link between child ADHD and youth depressive symptoms. Alain, Marcotte, Desrosiers, Turcotte, and Lafortune (this issue) use a large sample of adolescents with officially known criminality to pinpoint the nature and intensity of early abuse/maltreatment and later offense patterns. Di Giunta and colleagues (this issue) report on a longitudinal study conducted over three years in three countries, Colombia, Italy, and the USA. The study is about how well early adolescents believe they can control their anger experiences. Specifically, it asks whether early adolescents' self-efficacy beliefs about

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anger regulation can explain the relation between their parents' self-efficacy beliefs about anger regulation and these adolescents' internalizing and externalizing problems. The study by Pérez, Coo, and Irarrázabal ([this issue](#)), conducted in Chile, is a cross-sectional study, and it examines the association between maternal depression and perceived family cohesion and adaptability in both mothers and adolescents. The hypothesis proposed is that there is a higher perception discrepancy in mothers' and adolescents' views on family functioning when mothers show more severe signs of depression.

A *contextual perspective* is essential for understanding the role of triggering factors and moderating conditions. All behaviors occur in particular contexts, at different levels. In this Special Issue, Stattin and Latina examine adolescents' involvement in mutually hostile interactions in their everyday interpersonal settings (i.e., they are exposed to hostility and expose others to hostility) – at home with parents, at school with peers and teachers, and with people met in free-time. [Stattin and Latina \(this issue\)](#) propose that it is more dysfunctional to experience mutually hostile interactions across interpersonal settings than to experience such interactions in any one specific setting. This is because, in the first case, adolescents' interactions are likely to say something about the individual person's characteristic way of interacting with others. [Seiffge-Krenke \(this issue\)](#) studies differences in psychopathology at a cultural level. Her study, conducted in seven countries worldwide, examines how gender and inter-country differences relate to internalizing and externalizing symptoms after controlling for adolescents' stress perception and their coping style, and also maternal behaviors. The question raised is whether a clearer picture of gender and culture effects appears after controlling for these covariates.

What all the studies in this Special Issue have in common is that parenting and the family environment are assumed to play a key role in adolescents' adjustment and psychopathology. This assumption is in line with the conclusions drawn by both [Seiffge-Krenke \(this issue\)](#) and [Shulman and Scharf \(this issue\)](#). They attribute much of the recent change in adolescent psychopathology to stress and changes in parenting.

Finally, given that all the papers in this special issue are based on conference presentations at the 15th Biennial Conference of the European Association for Research on Adolescence (EARA), some more information on that conference is included in this introduction.

2. The origin of this special issue

The papers of this special issue are all based on conference papers presented at the 15th Biennial Conference of the European Association for Research on Adolescence (EARA). The conference took place September 16 to 19, 2016 in La Barrosa, Cadiz, Spain. The setting of this conference was superb, with sun, beach, palm trees, and a range of convenient hotels and restaurants. More importantly, we had nearly 400 delegates from 44 countries, with a considerable number of students and young researchers, which is great for the future of EARA and indicates a world-wide interest in the field of study. The range and variety of the pre-conference workshops on the day proceeding the start of the conference program attracted 70 participants, especially young researchers and doctoral students. The program included round-table discussions of issues such as longitudinal research design, public debates, films, innovative topics such as Jihadism, as well as our usual array of keynote speeches, symposia, posters and lectures. Indeed, the overarching theme of the conference emphasized future directions in youth research and highlighted a systemic theoretical framework for future adolescent studies from the opening keynote speech by Saskia Kunnen to discussions regarding the possibilities of longitudinal research and the necessity of looking beyond group means.

In order to provide a continuing flavor of local, Andalusian culture, flamenco dancing by young adolescents figured amongst the events within the Opening Ceremony and Reception, which was sponsored by Chiclana Town Council, and by an adult group of musicians, singers and dancer during the Formal Dinner at La Chaparral, where guests were transported by Chiclana's tourist 'trains' to and from the event, and where local dishes and wines were served buffet-style in the floodlit gardens and dining rooms of the hacienda while music played and guests inter-mingled till the witching hour.

Thanks are due to a number of individuals for their willing and enthusiastic support given to us in the preparation and carrying out of all the tasks necessary in arranging the conference. First, our student volunteers, who greeted and guided delegates as they arrived at train stations, bus stations, from airports and by hired car, set up lecture rooms and poster sessions, directed people around the conference venue and generally ensured that the day-to-day business ran smoothly – and they even managed to attend many sessions themselves, meeting senior international researchers whose work they may have read, practicing their English speaking abilities and networking with age-peers from other countries. Second, thanks to all our Spanish university colleagues in Seville and Madrid for their facilitating role in linking the two of us to officials and organizations beyond the reach of 'foreigners' like ourselves. Finally, and most gratefully, thanks to our business manager and third musketeer, Don Javier Marín, whose business acumen, entrepreneurial skills and local knowledge and social contacts made the structure of the four days around the academic program so complementary, memorable and 'value for money.'

A considerable number of interesting papers and posters investigating adolescent psychopathology were also presented. Especially papers focusing on recent psychopathology in our changing world were noticeable. As a consequence, the aim and theme of this special issue for the journal was decided to focus on adolescent psychopathology in times of change.

All presenters of these adolescent psychopathology related contributions were invited to submit abstracts for this special section. From 17 submitted abstracts, the guest editors selected a shortlist of 8 abstracts with great interrater reliability (intraclass correlation = .83). Selection was based on a set of criteria decided a priori, including the abstract being based on the 2016 conference program (origin), the topic matching the theme of this special issue, strong conceptualization of concepts and research questions, clear hypotheses, general interest of the research (content), sample, measures and analyses, credibility and method fitting in with the research questions (method), promising results and clear tables of figures (results), clinical relevance, and quality of English writing. Authors of selected abstracts then prepared and submitted their papers, of which 7 finally made it to this special section, after a

thorough and blind review process.

Overall, the studies that comprise this special issue use strong time and contextual perspectives to understand adolescent psychopathology today. As editors, we are delighted to contribute to this by presenting this special issue in *Journal of Adolescence*.

Acknowledgments

We thank most sincerely all participants who brought their interesting data and experience to La Barrosa, Cadiz, Spain as indicated by the high level of presentations and symposia. Thanks are also due to all sponsors of the conference, to the EARA Council, all our colleagues, friends and families for their support at different stages of preparation and running of the meeting. We deeply appreciate participants who prepared the papers in this special issue for publication.

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